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Parkinson Canada Menu

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Motor symptoms

Motor symptoms affect a person's movement and balance. They are often the symptoms that others can see.

Parkinson's is commonly characterized by four primary motor symptoms:

- Tremor
- Rigidity (stiffness)
- Slowness of movement (bradykinesia)
- Poor balance and coordination (postural instability)

Other motor symptoms of Parkinson's can include severe muscle cramping (dystonia), a mask-like face or loss of facial expression (hypomimia), small and crowded handwriting (micrographia) and decreased natural arm swing when walking.

There are several symptoms associated with Parkinson's. Not everyone will experience all these symptoms and people will have different experiences as their Parkinson's progresses.

Visit our Non-motor symptoms page for information on other symptoms, such as anxiety and depression, fatigue, pain and more.

Learn about non-motor symptoms

Primary motor symptoms

Tremor

A tremor is an involuntary shaking or quivering movement that affects part of the body, like the hand, arm, foot, leg or chin. Tremors usually begin on one side of the body, often in one hand. As Parkinson's progresses, tremors can spread to both sides and involve other parts of the body. The way tremors appear, develop, and progress varies from person to person. At any stage of Parkinson's, tremor can be a difficult symptom to control, interfering with daily activities that require fine motor skills, such as personal hygiene, getting dressed, writing or typing, and other activities.

Rigidity (stiffness)

Rigidity is when muscles become stiff or inflexible. People living with Parkinson's experience rigidity because their muscles lose the ability to stretch and relax, leading to discomfort, pain, muscle cramps, diminished range of motion, and problems with balance. Rigidity can contribute to decreased arm swing when walking, reduced facial expression and decreased sleep quality. Like tremor, rigidity usually appears on one side of the body and spreads to both sides over time.

Slowness of movement (bradykinesia)

Bradykinesia means slowness of movement. People living with Parkinson's can still move, but as their condition progresses, movements become slower and they will need additional time to complete tasks and daily activities. In Parkinson's, this slowness can appear in different ways, such as:

- Reduced automatic movements, such as blinking or arm swinging while walking
- Difficulty initiating movement, like rising from a chair or starting to walk
- A shift from a normal walking pace to shorter, shuffling steps
- Trouble getting in or out of bed
- Fatigue, as daily tasks take more effort and time
- Softer speech or changes in vocal strength and clarity

Poor balance and coordination (postural instability)

Postural instability, or difficulty balancing, combined with tremor, rigidity and slow movement can change how a person walks and increases the risk of falls. Parkinson's can affect the reflexes that help maintain balance, making some people feel unsteady when standing. It can also slow down reaction times, movement speed, and the body's ability to automatically adjust posture to stay upright.

What causes motor symptoms?

Dopamine is a neurotransmitter (a chemical substance) in the brain that carries signals between nerves that controls movement, balance & coordination. In people with Parkinson's, brain cells that produce dopamine don't work as well as they should. As Parkinson's progresses, more of these dopamine-producing cells are lost, making it harder for the brain to send signals that control movement.

Managing motor symptoms

Motor symptoms are often the most recognized signs of Parkinson's, but the good news is that they can usually be managed with the right combination of strategies. These may include:

- **Daily lifestyle and habit changes** that help keep the body strong, flexible, and mobile
  - Learn more at **Living better with Parkinson's**
- **Adjustments to medications** or exploring new treatment and therapy options
  - Learn more at **Treatments and therapies**
- **Assistive technologies** to help you with daily tasks gain more independence, and increase self-efficacy
- **Support from allied health professionals,** like physiotherapists, occupational therapists, and others who understand Parkinson's and can tailor care to the individual
  - Learn more at **Build your team**
- **Surgical interventions** such as Deep Brain Stimulation (DBS), when appropriate

Living well with Parkinson's requires a whole-body approach. It's not just about managing symptoms—it's about being actively involved in your own care. People who take an active role in their health decisions and daily routines often experience better outcomes, improved quality of life, and a stronger sense of control. You are a vital member of your care team.

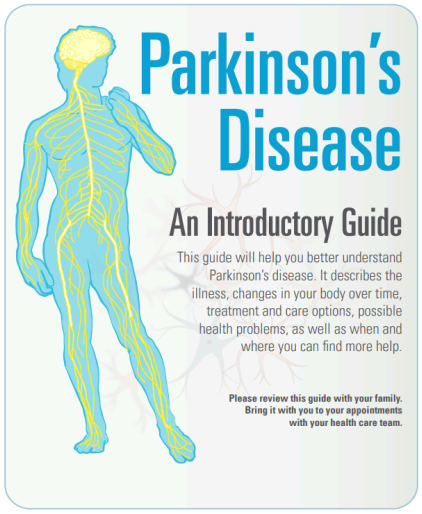
Learn more about Parkinson's symptoms and how to manage them

Not everyone will experience all the symptoms of Parkinson's and people will have different experiences as their condition progresses.

While each person experiences Parkinson's differently, understanding Parkinson's symptoms is an important step in managing the condition and maintaining quality of life.



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Parkinson's: An introductory guide

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